

POLITICAL OBSERVERS FEAR MODI IS HEADED THE INDIRA WAY. SO POWERFUL DID SHE BECOME IN THE '70s THAT ELECTIONS WERE FOUGHT AND WON IN HER NAME

OPPOSITION IN DISARRAY

What is likely to help the BJP cause in 2024 is the division and disarray among the Opposition. The Congress may have won Himachal, but in the numerical scheme of things, the state, with just four Lok Sabha seats, matters very little in the general election. The win in the hill state, therefore, is unlikely to add any significant political muscle to the party, given its two simultaneous humiliating defeats—in Gujarat, where the Congress tally plummeted to an embarrassing 17 seats from 77 in 2017, the worst-ever performance, and in the municipal polls in Delhi, where it emerged an insignificant third, winning a mere seven seats of the total 250.

That said, the victory in Himachal does break the streak of successive losses for the grand old party. The win has come despite Rahul Gandhi's absence, and highlights that in states where the Congress still has an organisation and there is no strong third party, it can take on the BJP's famed electoral machinery and render the Modi magic vulnerable. In Karnataka, which goes to election in May, the Congress not only has two towering CM aspirants in Siddaramaiah and D.K. Shivakumar but also a good cadre. Congress chances, therefore, are bright if it manages to keep the internal tussle for the top post under control. In MP, Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan, where it won the elections in 2018 but subsequently

